

Deacon Qualifications And Selection

Raising the Standard for Servant Leadership

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Contents

Introduction: The Standard Matters	1
Introduction: The Standard Matters	
Why the Standard Exists	3
Why the Standard Exists	
Worthy of Respect: The Character	7
Qualifications	
Worthy of Respect: The Character Qualifications	
Holding the Mystery and the Marriage	13
Qualifications	
Holding the Mystery and the Marriage Qualifications	
The Women Deacons Qualification and	18
the Spouse Consideration	
The Women Deacons Qualification and the Spouse Consideration	
Designing the Selection Process	22
Designing the Selection Process	
Retiring and Removing Deacons	28
Retiring and Removing Deacons	

Conclusion: Servants Worthy of the Calling		33
Conclusion: Servants Worthy of the Calling		
Appendix: Deacon Selection Tools		35
Appendix: Deacon Selection Tools		

Introduction: The Standard Matters

THE CHURCH THAT LOWERS its standard for deacons is making a statement about what the office is worth.

It is saying, in effect, that the people who serve communion, manage the building, and care for the vulnerable members of the congregation do not need to be people of genuine spiritual character. That the ministry of mercy can be performed by anyone willing to show up. That what matters about the diaconate is the body in the chair, not the soul behind it.

This conclusion is wrong. Not just theologically wrong, though it is that. Practically wrong, in ways that damage the ministry the diaconate is supposed to provide. The deacon who lacks self-control will manage the benevolence fund carelessly. The deacon who is double-tongued will gossip about the struggling families who are receiving the church's practical care. The deacon who is greedy for gain will use her ministry position to build social capital rather than to serve

The standard for the diaconate exists because the ministry of the diaconate matters. Not as governance, not as institutional management, but as the concrete, practical, highly personal work of caring for the congregation's most vulnerable members and meeting needs in the name of Christ. Work that significant deserves people that qualified.

This book is about helping churches find and select those people. It examines the 1 Timothy 3 qualifications for deacons in depth, addresses the specific practical challenges of applying them, and provides a framework for a selection process that takes them seriously. The goal is not to make the diaconate inaccessible. It is to make it genuinely meaningful — a calling that attracts people of genuine character and sends them into genuinely significant ministry.

Deacons likewise must be dignified, not double-tongued, not addicted to much wine, not greedy for dishonest gain. They must hold the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience. — 1 Timothy 3:8–9

CHAPTER ONE

Why the Standard Exists

SERVANT LEADERSHIP REQUIRES GENUINE servants

The qualifications for deacons in 1 Timothy 3:8–13 have a specific character that sets them apart from a competency list. They are not a description of organizational skills, administrative ability, or institutional effectiveness. They are a portrait of a person — a person whose interior life, relational patterns, and public reputation reflect the kind of genuine spiritual formation that servant leadership requires.

This is intentional. Paul knew what he was doing when he wrote these requirements. He was establishing that the holiness of the calling demanded a certain kind of person — not because service is more spiritually significant than preaching (though it is not less), but because the person who serves in the name of Christ becomes a representation of Christ in every interaction. The deacon who sits with a grieving widow is, in that moment, the church's visible presence in her life. The deacon who manages the

Character matters in these moments. It matters in ways that a competency-based standard can never capture.

THE DIGNITY OF THE DIACONAL CALLING

THE WORD PAUL USES to introduce the deacon qualifications in 1 Timothy 3:8 is *semnous* — dignified, serious, worthy of respect. This is the same family of words he uses in Titus 2 when he describes what older men, older women, and young men should model for the community. It carries the sense of someone whose life commands respect because of its genuine quality — not its impressiveness, but its integrity.

This is a high and specific starting point. Paul is saying that the deacon must be a person whose life, when honestly observed, generates genuine respect. Not universal admiration — genuine character does not always produce universal admiration, particularly in communities where character is not itself consistently valued. But honest respect. The kind of respect that comes from people who know someone well enough to assess them accurately and who conclude: this is a person whose life is genuinely ordered, genuinely honest, and genuinely worth following.

The church that selects deacons primarily on the basis of willingness, availability, or tenure is not applying this standard. A person can be willing and available without being dignified in the biblical sense. A person can have decades of

WHAT THE CHURCH LOSES WHEN THE STANDARD IS LOWERED

THE CONSEQUENCES OF A low deacon standard are specific and cumulative. They show up not in any single dramatic failure but in the slow erosion of the ministry quality that a genuinely qualified diaconate would have produced.

They show up in the benevolence ministry that is managed without compassion — where decisions are made bureaucratically rather than pastorally, where the family in need feels processed rather than cared for, where the gospel is not visible in the way help is given because the person giving the help has not been formed by the gospel in the ways the role requires.

They show up in the hospitality ministry that is technically functional but genuinely cold — where guests are greeted efficiently but not warmly, where the welcome does not feel personal because the person providing it has not been formed by the kind of genuine regard for others that genuine welcome requires.

They show up in the community's trust of the diaconate as a whole. When a congregation has learned, from experience, that the people in the deacon role are not reliably people of genuine character, the congregation disengages from the practical care systems the diaconate is supposed to provide. The family that needs help does not ask for it because they have reason to doubt that the person receiving the request

DEACON QUALIFICATIONS AND SELECTION

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What standard is your church currently applying to deacon selection? Is it primarily a character standard, a competency standard, or an availability standard?

What specific consequences has a lowered deacon standard produced in your congregation? Can you name specific instances where unqualified deacons damaged the ministry they were supposed to provide?

How does your congregation currently communicate the significance of the diaconal calling to potential candidates? Does the way you describe the role attract the kind of people the role requires?

What would it take to raise the standard in your specific context without it feeling punitive to the people currently serving?

CHAPTER TWO

Worthy of Respect: The Character Qualifications

WHAT PAUL MEANS AND how to assess it

Paul's list of deacon qualifications in 1 Timothy 3:8–13 is compact but rich. Each element describes a different dimension of the character that servant leadership requires. Taken together, they paint a picture of a person whose inner life has been genuinely formed by the gospel — someone who can be trusted with the practical expression of the community's care because the gospel has produced in them the character that trustworthy service requires.

DIGNIFIED: THE QUALITY OF THE WHOLE PERSON

WE EXAMINED SEMNOUS BRIEFLY in the previous chapter. Here it is worth dwelling more specifically on what it means for practical assessment.

The dignified person carries themselves with a quality that communicates seriousness of purpose. Not solemnity or

How do you assess this? You observe the person across multiple contexts and over time. You talk to people who know them in their ordinary life rather than only in their church context. You look for the consistency between who they appear to be and who those who know them well say they are. Dignity in the biblical sense is not self-presentation. It is the quality of a person whose character is genuinely integrated — the same in public as in private, the same under pressure as in comfort.

NOT DOUBLE-TONGUED: THE INTEGRITY OF SPEECH

THE PHRASE “NOT DOUBLE-TONGUED” (μετὰ διλογίας) appears only here in the New Testament. It describes the person who says one thing to one person and something different to another — whose words cannot be fully trusted because they are adjusted to the audience rather than grounded in genuine conviction.

The double-tongued person is not necessarily a liar. More often, they are a people-pleaser whose desire for social approval leads them to tell each person what that person wants to hear. They agree with the deacon who thinks the benevolence fund is too generous. They agree with the

In a diaconal context, this pattern is particularly damaging. The deacon who handles confidential information about struggling families, who manages the practical care needs of vulnerable members, who communicates the community's practical expressions of love to specific individuals — this person must be someone whose words can be trusted absolutely. The double-tongued deacon will gossip. Will misrepresent. Will tell each party in a conflict what they want to hear. The practical care ministry entrusted to them will be poisoned by the unreliability of their speech.

Assessing this qualification requires observing the candidate's speech patterns across contexts. What do they say about others when those others are not present? Do they say the same things about specific situations to different people, or do the accounts shift? Do people who have received their counsel trust what they were told, or have they discovered discrepancies? The double-tongued person is often difficult to catch in a single conversation. The pattern emerges across time and across observers.

NOT ADDICTED TO MUCH WINE: THE SELF-CONTROL PRINCIPLE

PAUL'S PROHIBITION OF EXCESSIVE wine consumption in 1 Timothy 3:8 carries the same principle we identified in the elder qualifications: the issue is self-control, and the specific prohibition is the instance of a broader

Applied to the contemporary context, this qualification asks: is this person self-governing? Do they control their appetites, or do their appetites control them? The addiction that Paul explicitly names is alcohol, but the principle extends to any pattern of compulsive behavior that indicates a loss of self-governance: addictive use of technology, compulsive spending, patterns of binge eating, substance use of any kind.

This is not a qualification about perfection. It is a qualification about pattern. The person who has struggled with an addiction in the past and who has moved through genuine repentance, recovery, and sustained change is not automatically disqualified. The person who is currently governed by a compulsive pattern they have not addressed is. The question is not whether the candidate has ever struggled but whether they are currently self-governing in a way that the demands of servant ministry require.

NOT GREEDY FOR DISHONEST GAIN: FINANCIAL INTEGRITY

PAUL'S PHRASE AISCHROKERDES — literally “pursuing shameful gain” — addresses the deacon's relationship with money and financial integrity. The deacon who is greedy for gain is the person who uses their position in the community to pursue financial benefit — whether through the management of financial resources in ways that serve their own interests, through the exploitation of the trust relationships that diaconal ministry creates, or through the use of their knowledge of members' financial

In the contemporary context, this qualification is particularly relevant for deacons who manage benevolence funds, who have access to the community's financial records, or who are involved in decisions about resource allocation. The temptation to benefit personally from financial access is real and has been realized in enough church contexts to make it a genuine concern rather than a hypothetical one.

But the qualification also addresses a more subtle form of financial motivation: the deacon who serves primarily to build social capital and professional reputation rather than to genuinely care for others. This form of "gain" is not financial but social, and it is perhaps more common than the financial version. The person who does community service primarily for the visibility it provides, who manages their service portfolio for professional networking purposes, who is more interested in being seen serving than in the actual people being served — this person has a form of the greedy-for-gain problem even if their financial integrity is technically sound.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

How does your current selection process assess the 'not double-tongued' qualification? Do you have ways of gathering information about candidates' speech patterns across contexts?

What compulsive patterns in a candidate's life would concern you under the 'not addicted' qualification? How would you address a concern in this area with sensitivity and directness?

How do you assess financial integrity in deacon candidates? Do you have specific questions you ask, or do you rely primarily on the absence of obvious problems?

DEACON QUALIFICATIONS AND SELECTION

CHAPTER THREE

Holding the Mystery and the Marriage Qualifications

DOCTRINE AND HOME LIFE as tests of genuine formation

The two qualifications Paul includes for deacons that most closely parallel the elder qualifications — doctrinal faithfulness and household leadership — are also the two most frequently neglected in deacon selection processes. This neglect is a mistake, because these qualifications address the two most fundamental dimensions of genuine Christian formation: what a person actually believes and how they actually live at home.

HOLDING THE MYSTERY OF THE FAITH WITH A CLEAR CONSCIENCE

PAUL'S REQUIREMENT IN 1 Timothy 3:9 that deacons “hold the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience” is a specific and important statement about the deacon's

The phrase “the mystery of the faith” refers to the revealed content of the Christian gospel — the things that were hidden and are now revealed in Christ Jesus. Paul uses similar language in Colossians 1:26–27, where he describes “the mystery hidden for ages and generations but now revealed to his saints — Christ in you, the hope of glory.” To hold the mystery of the faith is to hold the gospel itself — the content of Christian revelation as the church has received and confessed it.

Holding this mystery “with a clear conscience” adds a specific dimension: the deacon’s relationship to the faith they profess must be genuine rather than merely formal. They are not just reciting a creed. They are holding convictions that are genuinely their own, that they live by, and that they have not privately compromised. The “clear conscience” in Pauline usage refers to a conscience that is not accusatory — not convicting the holder of living in contradiction to what they profess.

The practical implication is significant. The deacon should be a person of genuine doctrinal stability who personally believes what the church teaches and lives consistently with what they profess. Not a theologian. Not someone who can discourse on the finer points of systematic theology. But someone who genuinely knows the gospel, genuinely believes it, and genuinely orders their life around it.

How do you assess this in a selection process? You have a genuine conversation about the candidate’s faith. Not a theological examination, but a personal inquiry: how did you come to faith? What does the gospel mean to you in practice? Is there any area where what you profess and how you live

HUSBAND OF ONE WIFE AND HOUSEHOLD MANAGEMENT

THE PARALLELS BETWEEN THE deacon qualifications and the elder qualifications are most explicit here. Deacons must be “the husband of one wife” (1 Timothy 3:12) and must “manage their children and their own households well” (3:12). The same standards that we examined in depth in Book Two of this series apply to deacon candidates.

The household is the proving ground of character. What a person is at home is what a person is. And the person who will be trusted with the practical care of vulnerable congregation members, with the management of community resources, with the representation of the community’s love in specific and concrete interactions — this person must be someone whose home life provides genuine evidence that they are capable of the care, the consistency, and the genuine regard for others that the ministry requires.

The “husband of one wife” qualification for deacons carries the same interpretive complexity it carries for elders: does it primarily address polygamy, marital history, or the quality of the candidate’s current marital character? The same framework applies: it is most helpfully understood as a statement about the deacon’s current marital character — a

The household management qualification is equally important for deacon candidates. The deacon who is managing the community's practical care is exercising a form of leadership that requires the same fundamental capacities — genuine presence, consistent follow-through, genuine care for those in their charge, the ability to maintain appropriate authority while remaining genuinely responsive to need — that good household leadership requires. The person who is not managing their own household well has demonstrated that they do not yet possess those capacities at the level the diaconal role requires.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

How does your selection process assess the 'holding the mystery of the faith' qualification? Is there a genuine personal faith conversation, or is doctrinal faithfulness assumed?

What does 'holding the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience' mean practically for your church's deacons? Is there specific doctrinal content they should be able to articulate and defend?

How do you assess household management in deacon candidates? Does the assessment go beyond a general impression of whether the candidate seems like a good spouse and parent?

Is there a current deacon candidate whose household life raises genuine concerns? How will you address that concern in the selection process?

HOLDING THE MYSTERY AND THE MARRIAGE
QUALIFICATIONS

The Women Deacons Qualification and the Spouse Consideration

1 TIMOTHY 3:11 AND its practical application

We addressed the question of women as deacons in Book Seven of this series, examining the exegetical options and the pastoral implications of each position. This chapter focuses on the specific practical application of 1 Timothy 3:11 in the context of a selection process, regardless of the theological position a church holds on formal female deacon installation.

The verse reads: “Women likewise must be dignified, not slanderers, but sober-minded, faithful in all things.” Whether “women” here refers to women who are themselves deacons or to deacons’ wives, the verse establishes specific standards that apply to the women in the diaconal context, and those standards deserve careful attention.

THE QUALIFICATIONS THEMSELVES

significantly with the qualifications for male deacons. “Dignified” is the same word (*semnas*) used for male deacons in 3:8 — the same quality of character that commands genuine respect. “Not slanderers” is the inverse of “not double-tongued” — a specific prohibition of the kind of malicious speech that destroys reputation and corrupts community. “Sober-minded” addresses the same quality of mental and emotional clarity that the male deacon qualifications address. And “faithful in all things” is a comprehensive character statement that encompasses integrity, reliability, and consistency across the full range of the person’s life and commitments.

These are high standards. They are the standards of a person formed by genuine Christian character, not merely by social convention or religious habit. And they apply with equal force regardless of whether the verse is understood to describe female deacons or deacons’ wives. Either way, the women who are most directly connected to the diaconate must be women of genuine character.

THE SPOUSE CONSIDERATION

FOR CHURCHES THAT UNDERSTAND 3:11 as referring to deacons’ wives, the verse establishes that the spouse of a deacon candidate is a relevant consideration in the selection process. The wife’s character will affect the deacon’s ministry in several specific ways.

First, the wife of a deacon will have access to confidential information about the congregation’s life. The deacon who comes home and discusses the pastoral care situations she has encountered — the struggling family whose financial

Second, the wife's attitude toward the ministry will significantly affect the deacon's capacity for sustained service. The diaconal ministry can be demanding of time and emotional energy. The wife who does not understand or support the demands of the ministry will create a persistent tension between the deacon's home life and ministry life that will eventually limit or damage one or both. The wife who is genuinely supportive, who shares her spouse's servant heart, and who regards the ministry as a shared calling rather than a competing obligation — this wife is a significant asset to the deacon's long-term effectiveness.

Including a brief conversation with a deacon candidate's spouse — not an interview, but a genuine personal engagement that assesses her character and her understanding of what the diaconate requires — is a valuable component of a thorough selection process. Its purpose is not to vet her as if she were the candidate but to ensure that the relational and domestic context within which the deacon will serve is genuinely supportive of the ministry.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

If your church includes women as formal deacons, how does the selection process apply the qualifications of 1 Timothy 3:11? Are those qualifications as carefully assessed

THE WOMEN DEACONS QUALIFICATION AND THE
SPOUSE CONSIDERATION

If your church understands 3:11 as referring to deacons' wives, does your selection process include any assessment of the spouse's character and attitude toward the ministry?

What specific concerns about a deacon candidate's spouse would raise questions for you about the candidate's fitness for the role? How would you address those concerns?

How does your congregation honor the women who are doing the practical work of diaconal ministry, whether formally titled or not?

CHAPTER FIVE

Designing the Selection Process

HOW TO ASSESS THE qualifications in practice

The qualifications in 1 Timothy 3:8–13 are only as effective as the process that applies them. A selection process that is too brief, too informal, or too deferential to social dynamics will produce deacons who have not been genuinely assessed against the standards. A selection process that is too extensive, too bureaucratic, or too interrogative will feel punitive and will discourage the people whose servant spirit the diaconate most needs.

The goal is a process that is thorough enough to genuinely surface character issues, warm enough to honor the candidate's dignity and calling, and clear enough in its standards that both the church and the candidate understand exactly what is being assessed and why. What follows is a practical framework for achieving that goal.

WHO NOMINATES AND HOW

the tone for everything that follows. A nomination process that is vague, passive, and unguided will produce candidates who are nominated primarily because they are available and willing – the characteristics that should be necessary but not sufficient for the office. A nomination process that is specific, guided, and connected to the church’s articulated theology of the diaconate will produce candidates who are nominated because someone who knows them well believes they have the genuine character and gifts the office requires.

The most effective nomination processes combine a general invitation with specific pastoral guidance. The general invitation goes to the congregation: “We are looking for deacon candidates, and we welcome nominations.” But the general invitation is accompanied by specific pastoral investment: the pastor and existing deacons are actively identifying people whose lives demonstrate the character the qualifications describe and are having direct, personal conversations with those people about the possibility of serving.

The self-nomination should be possible – Paul says that aspiring to the office of deacon is to aspire to a noble task – but it should be received within the same assessment process as any other nomination. The person who puts their own name forward is not automatically more or less qualified than the person whose name is submitted by someone else.

THE INITIAL CONVERSATION

EVERY PERSON NOMINATED FOR the diaconate deserves a genuine conversation before any formal

The conversation should cover: what the candidate understands the diaconate to be and what drew them to it; their sense of calling and what gifts they believe they bring to this specific ministry; a brief account of their faith story and current spiritual life; and an honest description of what the role requires in terms of time, emotional investment, and character standard. The candidate who responds to this description with genuine eagerness rather than qualification is already demonstrating something significant about their readiness.

The initial conversation is also an opportunity to share the 1 Timothy 3 qualifications explicitly and to invite the candidate's honest self-assessment. "These are the standards Paul describes for this office. As you read them, where do you see yourself clearly meeting the standard? Where do you have honest uncertainty?" The candidate who engages this self-assessment with genuine honesty rather than defensive performance is demonstrating exactly the kind of self-knowledge the role requires.

THE ASSESSMENT CONVERSATIONS

BEYOND THE INITIAL CONVERSATION with the candidate, a thorough assessment process includes two additional conversations: a reference conversation with people who know the candidate well, and — for married candidates — a conversation with the spouse.

The reference call produces genuinely useful information only if it is conducted as a genuine conversation rather than as a form-filling exercise. The reference who is given space to speak freely, who is asked specific questions that require honest engagement rather than general positive assessments, will provide information that a formal application process never surfaces.

TESTING BEFORE FORMAL INSTALLATION

PAUL'S INSTRUCTION IN 1 Timothy 3:10 deserves more attention than it typically receives: "And let them also be tested first; then let them serve as deacons if they prove themselves blameless." Testing before installation is not optional. It is a structural requirement of the selection process.

What does testing look like in the contemporary context? It looks like assigning the candidate meaningful service responsibility in the area of ministry they are being considered for before they are formally installed. The person being considered for benevolence ministry leads a case for

The testing period is not a probationary humiliation. It is a gift to both the candidate and the church — it confirms the calling, develops the skills, and ensures that the formal installation is recognizing demonstrated faithfulness rather than assumed potential. The candidate who moves through a testing period with genuine faithfulness and genuine growth has provided the strongest possible evidence of fitness for the office.

THE INSTALLATION SERVICE

THE FORMAL INSTALLATION OF deacons deserves the same theological weight that the installation of elders deserves. The diaconate is a holy calling, and the community's formal commissioning of its deacons should communicate that holiness.

A meaningful deacon installation includes a Scripture charge — Acts 6:1–7 and 1 Timothy 3:8–13 are the natural texts — that frames the office and its requirements. It includes a public affirmation by the candidate of their calling, their understanding of the role, and their commitment to its demands. It includes the laying on of hands by the pastoral staff and existing deacons, as a solemn recognition of the calling and a blessing on the ministry. And it includes

The installation that feels significant will shape how the newly installed deacon approaches the role. The installation that feels like a brief acknowledgment from the pulpit will communicate to the deacon and to the congregation that the role is brief and acknowledgment-worthy. The community's theology of the diaconate is communicated as much by how it installs its deacons as by what it says about the office.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What changes would you make to your current nomination process if the goal was to attract candidates who are nominated because of their demonstrated character rather than their availability?

Does your selection process include a genuine reference conversation that asks specific, targeted questions about the qualifications? What questions would you add?

How does your church currently handle the 'testing first' requirement of 1 Timothy 3:10? Is there a genuine testing period, or is installation the first meaningful ministry responsibility?

What would a theologically significant deacon installation service look like in your context? How would you make the weight of the calling felt in the room?

CHAPTER SIX

Retiring and Removing Deacons

HONORING THE PAST AND protecting the future

The selection of qualified deacons is only half the work of building a healthy diaconate. The other half — equally important and far less frequently addressed — is the ongoing stewardship of the diaconate over time: the gracious honoring of deacons who have faithfully served and are now ready to transition to a different role, and the direct and courageous addressing of deacons who are no longer meeting the qualifications the office requires.

Both dimensions of this stewardship are necessary for a healthy diaconate. A diaconate that never retires anyone gradually fills with people whose active ministry has ended but whose institutional position has not changed. A diaconate that never removes anyone gradually fills with people whose character no longer meets the standard but whose tenure has made the conversation seem impossible. In either case, the ministry the diaconate is supposed to provide is

HONORING THE TRANSITION: THE EMERITUS CONVERSATION

THE DEACON WHO HAS served faithfully for decades and whose season of active diaconal ministry is winding down deserves to be honored, not simply replaced. The honor is not just personal kindness — it is a theological statement about the dignity of the service they have rendered. The servant leader who has cared for widows, welcomed strangers, met practical needs, and stewarded the community's resources for thirty years has done holy work. The congregation owes them a clear and genuine recognition of that work, not a perfunctory acknowledgment that fades as their practical involvement decreases.

The emeritus conversation is the transition conversation that honors the past while opening the future. It is not the conversation that says “You are no longer qualified.” It is the conversation that says: “You have served faithfully and with genuine distinction. We want to honor that. And we want to talk about what the next season of your relationship with this church looks like.”

For many longtime deacons, the emeritus conversation opens a discussion about what wisdom and relationship they can continue to offer without the formal institutional responsibility of active deacon service. The man who spent thirty years managing the benevolence fund may not be able to continue the active management, but his knowledge of the

THE ANNUAL DEACON REVIEW

THE MOST EFFECTIVE TOOL for preventing both the drift into emeritus status without a conversation and the accumulation of unaddressed character concerns is the annual deacon review. This is not a performance review in the institutional sense. It is a pastoral conversation, conducted by the senior pastor or a designated elder, with each deacon about how their ministry is going and how they are doing personally.

The annual review should include: an honest assessment of the deacon's ministry activity and effectiveness in the past year; a genuine inquiry into the deacon's personal spiritual life and household health; an honest conversation about any concerns that have arisen; and a discussion of the deacon's continued sense of calling to the role. This last element is the one most likely to surface the natural transition conversations that avoid the need for more formal action. Most deacons who are ready to step back from active service will say so if they are genuinely asked whether they still feel called to the role. Most deacons who are experiencing personal challenges that are affecting their ministry will share them if they are asked in the context of a genuine pastoral relationship.

THE REMOVAL OF A deacon for failure to meet the qualifications follows the same general principles as the removal of an elder, with two significant differences in degree. First, because the governance stakes are lower, the process can be somewhat more straightforward. The deacon who is no longer meeting the qualifications is not carrying the same institutional authority as an elder, and their removal, while significant, typically produces less congregational disruption. Second, because the relational character of the diaconate is so central, the process should be even more consistently pastoral — framed as care for the person rather than institutional housekeeping.

The most common basis for deacon removal is not dramatic moral failure. It is the gradual drift of character in ways that have slowly disqualified the person from the office they still technically hold. The deacon who has become double-tongued in ways that are damaging the congregation's practical care relationships. The deacon whose relationship with money has become problematic in ways that are affecting how she manages the benevolence fund. The deacon whose marriage has deteriorated to the point that his household is visibly disordered. These are not the situations that make obvious demands for action. They are the situations that require the kind of patient, direct, caring pastoral conversation that most churches avoid until the situation becomes undeniable.

The framework for these conversations is the same one developed in Book Five of this series for elder removal: private confrontation first, elder team engagement if needed,

Note: The deacon removal process should always be accompanied by a genuine pastoral care plan for the departing deacon. Removal from office is not abandonment of the person.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Does your church have an active emeritus pathway for longtime deacons whose season of active service is ending? Is there a gracious and honoring conversation happening, or is the transition being avoided?

How does your church currently conduct annual deacon reviews? Are they genuine pastoral conversations, or are they institutional check-ins?

Is there a current deacon whose character or situation raises genuine questions about their continued qualification? Has there been a direct conversation, or has the concern been allowed to accumulate without address?

What would you say to a deacon you need to retire or remove that genuinely honors their past service while being honest about the present situation?

Conclusion: Servants Worthy of the Calling

THE STANDARD PAUL ESTABLISHES for deacons in 1 Timothy 3 is not a bureaucratic threshold. It is a portrait of the kind of person through whom God does the work of practical mercy in the world.

The church that selects its deacons with genuine care — that takes the qualifications seriously, invests in a thorough assessment process, tests candidates before installation, and maintains ongoing accountability for those who serve — will find that the quality of its practical care ministry rises dramatically. Needs are met more consistently. Vulnerable members are known more thoroughly. Guests are welcomed more genuinely. And the congregation develops the kind of practical love for one another that the watching world finds most compelling.

The church that selects its deacons carelessly — that installs willing people without genuine assessment, that allows the standard to erode under the pressure of

The standard is not a burden. It is a gift — to the congregation that is served by genuinely qualified servants, to the deacons whose ministry is meaningful and effective because their character is genuine, and to the God who takes delight in the faithfulness of the servants he has called to care for the world he loves.

Find the people Paul describes. Assess them carefully. Test them first. Install them with weight. And watch the mercy ministry of your congregation become one of its most powerful witnesses to the gospel.

For those who serve well as deacons gain a good standing for themselves and also great confidence in the faith that is in Christ Jesus. — 1 Timothy 3:13

Appendix: Deacon Selection Tools

A. DEACON CANDIDATE SELF-ASSESSMENT

Complete this document honestly before your first assessment conversation. Bring it with you.

Dignified: How do others who know you in ordinary life — not just at church — describe you? Is your reputation consistent across contexts?

Not double-tongued: Are you consistent in what you say to different people about the same situation? Can people trust that what you tell them represents what you actually believe?

Self-controlled: Are there any patterns of appetite, behavior, or emotion that you struggle to govern consistently? How are you addressing them?

Financial integrity: How do you handle money? Is there any dimension of your financial life that would concern the church if they knew about it?

Holding the faith: How would you describe the gospel in your own words? Is there any area where what you profess and how you live feel out of alignment?

Sense of calling: What draws you to the diaconate? What specific gifts do you believe you bring to this role?

Availability: What does your realistic availability for this ministry look like? Are there constraints on your time that the church should know about?

B. Reference Call Framework

Use this framework when calling references for deacon candidates.

How do you know [name], and in what contexts have you observed them?

How would you describe their character? What words come to mind?

Have you observed them in situations of stress or conflict? How did they handle those situations?

How do they speak about other people when those people are not present?

Have you ever observed inconsistency between how they present themselves publicly and how they actually behave in private or in difficult moments?

How would you describe their relationship with money?

Do you know their spouse? What is your impression of their household?

Is there anything about this person's character or life that you think the church should know before placing them in a position of significant pastoral responsibility?

C. A Sample Deacon Installation Charge

[Name], you have been nominated, examined, tested in

You are called to serve this congregation in the name of the God who himself came not to be served but to serve. You are called to know the practical needs of this community, to meet those needs with the resources God has entrusted to this body, and to do so with dignity, discretion, and genuine compassion.

You are called to hold the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience — to be a person whose character and whose belief are genuinely integrated, who represents Christ well in every practical interaction because the Christ you represent has genuinely transformed who you are.

The people you will serve are watching. What they see when they encounter you in your ministry is what they will believe about the community that sent you and the God that community serves. Serve them in a way that makes them glad to know both.

[Name], do you accept this calling and commit to fulfill it faithfully, with God's help?

(Candidate responds: I do, with God's help.)